North Airport Drive Civic Association

Protecting Our Community — The Facts

The Chickahominy River: A State Scenic River

The Chickahominy River is an 87-mile Coastal Plain river designated as a **State Scenic River** by the Virginia General Assembly under Virginia Code § 10.1-410.1. This designation requires state agencies to consider the river's scenic, recreational, historic, and natural values during any planning or permitting process. Dam construction on the river requires direct approval from the General Assembly.

The Virginia Department of Conservation and Recreation describes the tidal freshwater vegetation along the Chickahominy as **"the most impressive in the Mid-Atlantic region."** The river feeds Chickahominy Lake, a 1,230-acre reservoir that supplies **drinking water to the City of Newport News**.

Wildlife & Endangered Species

The lower Chickahominy watershed has been recognized as harboring **"some of the most biologically diverse and ecologically significant areas in the Coastal Zone of Virginia"** by the Virginia DCR. Documented species include:

Status	Species
Endangered	Atlantic sturgeon, Sensitive joint-vetch, Peregrine falcon
Threatened	Bald eagle (state), Canebrake rattlesnake, Loggerhead sea turtle
Protected	Bald eagle (federal), Great blue heron rookeries
Rare	American shad, Hickory shad, River herring

River herring are so depleted that Virginia enacted a **moratorium on possession in 2012** — all river herring caught must be immediately released.

Ecological Cores at Risk

The Virginia Natural Landscape Assessment identifies **multiple C1 and C2 rated ecological cores** in the Chickahominy corridor — the highest significance rankings. The lower watershed contains **5 conservation sites rated B1 (Outstanding)**. The DCR warns:

> *"Habitat loss is the greatest threat to biodiversity. Conversion of natural land to residential and commercial development is the primary mechanism by which habitat is lost permanently in Virginia."*
>
> *"Any fragmentation of ecological cores will result in an obligatory loss of benefits."*

Water, Soil & Septic Systems

Natural land absorbs approximately **40% of rainfall** into groundwater and produces only **10% surface runoff**. Dense development with impervious surfaces reverses this: only **5% is absorbed** while **55% becomes surface runoff**, carrying pollutants into streams and the Chesapeake Bay.

Henrico County identifies approximately **9,353 properties on septic systems**, with **4,171 located within Chesapeake Bay Preservation Areas**. The Comprehensive Plan requires **100% reserve drainfield area** for all septic systems in these areas. Nearby development that changes how water moves through the landscape can alter soil conditions and **cause neighboring septic systems to fail**, contaminating groundwater that residents draw from their wells.

Traffic & Safety Concerns

Our roads were built for rural traffic — **narrow, two-lane roads with ditch drainage, no sidewalks, and limited sight lines**. The Henrico Comprehensive Plan describes Rural area roads as **"characterized by paved roads with ditch drainage"** — infrastructure fundamentally incompatible with dense development traffic.

A single-family home generates approximately **10 vehicle trips per day** (Institute of Transportation Engineers). A 130-home subdivision would add roughly **1,300 daily vehicle trips** to roads never designed for that volume.

Your Legal Protections

Virginia Code § 15.2-2283 states that zoning ordinances shall be designed to **"protect against danger and congestion in travel and transportation"** and to **"reduce or prevent congestion in the public streets."**

The **Henrico County Comprehensive Plan** requires that new development be **compatible with existing communities**:

- **Rural Keystone Policy #1:** Promote continuation of the historic, rural pattern as the desired character
- **Rural Residential:** Lots should be **no less than one (1) acre**
- **General Development Policy #7:** Discourage strip development along thoroughfares

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What You Can Do

1. **Join the Association** — Visit highlandspringszoning.com/get-involved
2. **Attend Board of Supervisors & Planning Commission meetings** — Your voice matters in public hearings
3. **Talk to your neighbors** — Share this fact sheet and spread the word
4. **Contact your Supervisor** — Varina District Supervisor Tyrone E. Nelson: (804) 501-4208

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*All facts on this sheet are sourced from official government documents, Virginia state law, and peer-reviewed scientific reports. Full citations and source links are available at **highlandspringszoning.com/history**.*

North Airport Drive Civic Association — Highland Springs, Varina District, Henrico County, Virginia